

Greatness in the Kingdom of God

Jesus Answers the Question of Greatness With a Child

In Matthew 18:1, we begin talking about greatness in the kingdom of God.

Greatness. Honor. Respect. Authority. Greatness in the kingdom.

How does it come? Why does it come? What is it about the Spirit of Jesus Christ operating in you that demands the respect of sinner and believer alike, and demands respect from principalities and powers?

What is it, and how does it come?

At the same time came the disciples unto Jesus,
saying,
Who is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?

Who has the most honor, the most respect, the most authority? Who is great? We want to know.

Notice what Jesus did:

And Jesus called a little child unto him,
and set him in the midst of them,
And said,
Verily I say unto you,
Except ye be converted,
and become as little children,
ye shall not enter into the kingdom of heaven.
Whosoever therefore shall humble himself as this little child,
the same is greatest in the kingdom of heaven.

Stop.

Is it not amazing that they asked Jesus who was greatest in the kingdom, and of all things He took a child and set him in their midst? What amazes me even more is that He used this little child to illustrate greatness in the kingdom of God.

Every Calling Must Pass Through the Same Mill of Humility

I am not going to lie to you and fall into some false humility. I am not going to do it, because I know God has called me to do something in the kingdom of God.

But I know more than that. I know He has called you to do something in the kingdom. One thing I have found out is that God does not have pets. I do not care what your name is. If you are going to draw close to God, you are going to go through the same mill.

Whether apostle, prophet, teacher, preacher, evangelist, miracle worker, healer, helps, governments, or diversities of tongues, you are a member in particular, called by God, you and you alone, to fulfill your specific place in the kingdom of God.

What denotes this greatness in His kingdom?

I am not going to lie and tell you I do not want to fulfill, to absolute maximum capacity, the position He has called me to fulfill in His body, whether that be helps, governments, or miracle worker.

I do not ask much. I am an evangelist with two anointings. One is the perfecting of the saints, which is happening in you right now as you sit in your chair. The apostle, prophet, teacher, preacher, and evangelist are given for the maturing and perfecting of the saints. Not only your pastor, who is in that lineup, is given to you for that maturing. I, the evangelist, am also given to you. I belong to you for the same reason.

My dual anointing also demands the evangelism of the lost. I have two, and neither one will leave me alone.

I am not asking much. All I want to do is cut a swath a yard deep and a mile wide around the world two or three times and take a few million home with me. Is that too much to ask?

What are you asking?

A Little Child Is Trusting, Quick to Forgive, and Teachable

What denotes greatness in the kingdom of God? Jesus says unless you humble yourself and become as this little child.

What an amazing thing to say. They were asking for greatness. Who is the head one in the kingdom? Jesus says, "You have to humble yourself like this little child."

They might have thought, "Wait a minute. The Pharisees and Sadducees do not act like that at all. What are You talking about? Humble yourself as a little child?"

Would that not launch you into doing a study on what a little child is like? If greatness in the kingdom, maximum fulfillment of what He called you to do, absolute authority over principalities and powers, and authority to complete what God called you to do depended on this, would you not study a little child?

I have been blessed. After we had three of our own, my wife went out and got a couple more. I have studied little children ever since we have been married, and if I do not stop her, she will go get a couple more. I will be studying them all my life.

I have found out that He says, "Except you be converted," number one, "and become as this little child." That tells me that when I was born again, converted, I came into the world as a strapping youngster.

As I studied a little child, I thought, "God, what is it about him that You want us to be?"

I took the traditional view for a while. What is a little child like? A little child is trusting. He is all trusting. The example I heard the most was that you can set him on the platform and say, "Jump," and he will jump trustingly into your arms.

But just miss him once.

As I got into it further, I found a more valuable attribute of a child. How many of you ever had your child get into a fight with a neighbor's child, and then it drew you into it? You were fighting with the parents. The problem is that thirty minutes later the children have made up because a child is very quick to forgive, while you lasted a year.

A little child is very quick to forgive and repent. That is one attribute of a child.

The second attribute is this: unless you are converted and become as this little child. When I was born again, it was not very long before I was filled with the Holy Ghost and came out a tongue-talker. I learned how to talk in the Spirit. Here I was, full of the Holy Ghost, my Teacher, a tongue-talker, ultra-holy. I proved I was holy by putting everybody else down. It made me higher.

I thought, "You talk in tongues, you are okay, because you have the Teacher on the inside."

But there are people who talk with tongues. A man can get up and say, "Run off to Guyana with me. We will drink arsenic and be okay," and they never know when the man has crossed the line.

Not only do you have your Teacher on the inside of you, but you have to learn how to listen to Him.

That is the way a strapping youngster is. He is one thousand percent teachable. He will eat anything you give him.

Another attribute of a child is that he is one thousand percent teachable. If you tell him A is A, A is A. If you tell him two and two is three, he will believe you until he goes to school. Then he will probably just think you are innocent and dumb.

A child is one thousand percent teachable, and that is what Jesus means when He says to humble yourself as this little child: become one thousand percent teachable.

Receiving a Teachable Little One Is Receiving Jesus

How do you know that is what it means? Elementary, Watson. Look at the next verse:

Whosoever therefore shall humble himself as this little child,
the same is greatest in the kingdom of heaven.
And whoso shall receive one such little child in my name
receiveth me.

A child is trusting, quick to forgive, and teachable. That is why Jesus said what He did in verse 5.

Can you understand what He is saying? When you get a little teachable one on your hands, He says it is the same as receiving Jesus.

Somewhere along the progression of Jesus' teaching, we went from being the humble, all-trusting, teachable child to the one who receives the child who is one hundred percent teachable. Whether you are the child or have become the one receiving the child, He says to take heed, because it is the same as receiving Jesus.

That is why He put this stiff warning in the next verse:

But whoso shall offend one of these little ones which believe in me,
it were better for him that a millstone were hanged about his neck,
and that he were drowned in the depth of the sea.

To offend one of these little ones means to put an offensive stumbling block in front of him, usually in the area of teaching. It means teaching him something that is not God while claiming it is God, putting a stumbling block in front of him that holds him where he is until he ends up fruitless.

Jesus says whoever offends one of these little ones had better look out, because he is offending Jesus.

God's Love Must Be Perfected Through Other People

I have to stop and say this. I have been through an experience. I have been gone, and God has had me before Him again.

I have explained this to you many times. There is something inside me that will not leave me alone. There is something out there to be had that I, and nobody else I have talked to, knows how to have. God told me there is no use trying to go to anybody anymore, and not to think I am not teachable. He said I have been to Him.

There is a realm God wants to bring here. My God, you would think the book of Acts had come alive again. You would not be able to get near the meeting. It would be like a football game. You could not even get close enough to park. You would have to lay your sick in the street.

He wants to do it again.

I went before God, wanting my mountain to move and get out of my way. Like every time before, I entered into it half deceived:

"God, the problem must be with You, because You are not moving the mountain out of my way."

He said, "I cannot, son. You are the mountain."

I thought He was going to reveal majestic things, and all He did was show me what was wrong with me.

First John 4:12 says:

No man hath seen God at any time.
If we love one another,
God dwelleth in us,
and his love is perfected in us.

I have not had a problem loving God. I have had problems loving people.

I found out I could only go so far in God before coming up against a perimeter that brings you to a stop unless you are willing to have His love perfected in you. The only way that will be perfected is in your dealings with other people, as we love one another.

Kingdom Authority Comes by Serving, Not by Force

He said to the mother of Zebedee's children, and then to the ten disciples who were moved with indignation at her request, that her sons sit in positions of authority on the left and right hand of Jesus when He entered His kingdom.

She thought it would be a natural kingdom. She thought He was going to overthrow the Roman Empire, and that her two sons would have mighty positions of authority right next to Jesus. It made the other ten so mad that it moved them with indignation.

Jesus called them over, and they never mentioned it again.

He said, "Among the Gentiles, the princes of the Gentiles exercise dominion over them, and they do it by force. Then there are the great ones who exercise authority over the princes. They have this great authority, and they execute it by force."

But in the kingdom of God, authority and greatness do not come that way.

He said:

Whosoever will be great among you,
let him be your minister;
And whosoever will be chief among you,
let him be your servant.

As high as you can go in God, it is servant. Greatness in the kingdom does not come any other way.

Grace Established Him Before Repentance Exposed His Faults

Many days into this, He came into my room. Not in physical presence, good Lord, but He came in the anointing. It got hold of me like nothing ever had before.

He said to me, "Son, by faith you have access into this grace wherein you stand."

He did not use King James on me, but that is what He said. Grace will cover a multitude of faults and a multitude of sins. It covers us in righteousness while we operate as human beings with a million and one faults.

He said, "Son, that same grace will reign as a priest and a king in righteousness in this life."

He wiped my slate squeaky clean. Everything that had been held against me, every fault, everything I did wrong in my family and in raising my family, every wrong move and every wrong judgment, He wiped it so clean that the feeling of it came on the inside of me.

I had never felt anything like that in a hundred years. I knew it was necessary, but I did not know why.

Three or four days later, repentance came so heavily that I cried hard. Had He not first established me on my righteous rock, I do not know if I could have survived it, because I cried until I was dry. I was so sorry.

If you ask Him what is wrong, do not think He cannot show it. Trust me.

Offending Little Ones Means Flesh Must Be Cut Off at Any Cost

Now the greater understanding of these verses is coming. Somewhere along the line, this great authority, this respect demanded by principalities and powers, this total spirit of accuracy, comes because you are being taught by the Spirit and have humbled yourself until you become a servant teacher, privileged to receive little ones who are so hungry.

Four or five years ago, when He was trying to get this over to me, He showed me this last part.

Verse 7 says:

Woe unto the world because of offences!
for it must needs be that offences come;
but woe to that man by whom the offence cometh!

Woe to the man causing these little trusting, teachable children to fall.

Then He says:

Wherefore if thy hand or thy foot offend thee,
cut them off,
and cast them from thee:
it is better for thee to enter into life halt or maimed,
rather than having two hands or two feet
to be cast into everlasting fire.
And if thine eye offend thee,
pluck it out,
and cast it from thee:
it is better for thee to enter into life with one eye,
rather than having two eyes
to be cast into hell fire.
Take heed that ye despise not one of these little ones;
for I say unto you,
That in heaven their angels do always behold the face of my Father which is in heaven.

In other words, there is an angel standing in the presence of God on behalf of every little trusting, forgiving, teachable one who has been born again. Jesus says to take heed. They do not like it.

He said if your eye offends you, pluck it out. If your hand or foot offends you, cut it off. We know He is not talking about your literal hand and foot. That would be stupid. This is the temple of God.

You can defile this temple with a long tongue, with your tongue growing two or three feet longer than your mouth, sitting in the front room and licking a spoon in the kitchen. There are other ways. You can destroy your body through drugs, liquor, cigarettes, and chewing tobacco. This temple God gave you is a perfect piece of machinery, meant to serve you as you serve God. He made provision for it.

"What if I do not get healed?"

Keep on. You will.

"Did I do something?"

Not necessarily. You could have done something right and made the devil mad. I make him mad all the time. When I do, I find out how much power he still has in my life.

Authority is not authority until you can execute it. You can say all you want about it, but execute it, and buddy, you have it.

"How much authority do you have?"

I do not know. I will tell you when I stop him, and I will tell you how long it took me.

What is Jesus talking about when He says your hand offends you? He is not talking about your literal hand. He is talking about flesh, the operation of carnality. He says, "Take heed that you offend not one of these little ones." Woe to the man by whom these offenses come. Therefore, if your hand offends you, cut it off.

He is talking about the operation of the flesh, the things in you that are offensive.

The Vision of Cutting Off the Hand Showed the Cost of Servanthood

How did I find this out? Through a vision.

Sometimes my lightning-quick mind even scares me. He has to get the ABC blocks out and say, "Do you have it yet?" If the blocks do not work, then the visions are black and white. If that does not work, they come in color. But He eventually gets it over, because he who hungers and thirsts after righteousness shall be filled again and again and again.

No good thing is hidden, not from me. If there is anything I know, I know that. If I do not have it, I know where I can get it.

I was meditating in my office late into the night, in the house in Medford, Oregon. I had my feet propped up on my desk, leaning back, meditating, and I drifted off. Of course, you have never done that.

I was trying to get past that verse. I said, "What are You talking about here, God? You say, 'Whosoever offends a little one,' and then You say, 'If your hand offends you, cut it off.' What in the world does that have to do with offending a little one? Now You are telling us to cut our hand off. What are You talking about?"

Then I drifted off. What brought me out of my slumber was the vision.

Somehow I was in a car racing up a dirt road. I do not know how I did it, but I ran off the road. The car tipped over and somehow pinned my hand under it. Then it caught on fire. I knew I had approximately thirty seconds to decide whether to stay there and die in the explosion or cut my hand off, because I could not pull it out.

I made the decision to dismember. Do not ask me where the knife came from. This was a vision. I reached in my pocket, got my knife out, and it was vivid. He wanted me to remember. I cut through the bone and snapped it, all the way around.

I was running from the wreck, holding my arm. Then it exploded, and I came out of it.

Coming out of it, He began to talk to me about the revelation involved in it. He said, "Son, how often has a person been called upon to be dismembered? It is not too often. I want you to look at the things that are offensive in your life, the things that are wrong, in the same light and in the same magnitude. To become that servant, at any cost, cut it off. Get rid of it."

"What if I do not?"

"Then you will always have the servants looking after you."

Will you make it? God, yes, you are going to make it. Redemption is not based on your works. Redemption is based on you receiving by faith the grace He provided for you through the cross. You cannot earn it. You did not deserve it, yet it is an act of faith that appropriates this in your life. That gets you to heaven.

Everything else you do is born out of love, because nothing can be earned.

Thank God, for you hungry ones, that He has outlined a way to become the highest form of servant there is.

He called that greatness in the kingdom.